

have imagined the public fury his action would ignite. Most people believed the judge had been moved against because of his potential threat to Musharraf's future as head of the state. He became the icon for a movement by those unaffected by Musharraf's dispensation and his visits to various cities to address the bars there drew the kind of public response that political leaders dream of. As the independent electronic media beamed pictures of his massive receptions all over Pakistan, there were ample signs of the government getting rattled. Its attempts to restrict the live coverage by television news channels—drew even more flak from the media and the public at large.

In addition, the reportage of the daily hearings in the Supreme Court was also showing up the government in a bad light and steadily raising the political temperature. At one point, for example, the sc threw out the entire file of 'evidence' against the chief justice because it considered it 'scandalous' to the judiciary. It was also discovered that judges' residences and offices had been bugged by intelligence agencies. Such was the anger of the sc's full court bench that it fined the Government Rs 1,00,000 for scandalising the judiciary, suspended the licence of a government lawyer, banned intelligence officials from entering any of the higher courts and summoned the law secretary for explanations.

In this overwrought context, Musharraf would probably have welcomed the sc ruling since it defused some of the tension and took away for the time being the focus from an even bigger immediate challenge to his rule—his open confrontation with religious extremists.

When Musharraf launched the military operation against the militants holed up in Lal Masjid in Islamabad on July 10, many speculated that the General was using it as a ploy to distract attention from his judicial woes. The use of military force showed him in a decisive mode, after he had been criticised severely for dithering over the vigilantism of the Lal Masjid brigade. But as the army wiped out all the armed resistance inside the mosque and the perception mounted that the Government was hiding the exact death toll—the Government claimed

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MUSHARRAF SEEMS TO HAVE PLAYED THE RESTORATION CARD AFTER THE VERDICT OF THE SUPREME COURT WITH GRACE

102 people including 10 commandos were killed, while rumour-mongers insisted that over a thousand people had died—the tide turned against Musharraf again. The tipping point may have come when Maulana Abdul Aziz, the firebrand head of Lal Masjid who had tried to flee the mosque in a burqa, was forced to appear in the same garment for an interview on Pakistan Television hours after he was arrested. Suddenly there was a feeling the Government had gone too far. Islamist hardliners dubbed the slain deputy head of the mosque—Aziz's younger brother Abdul Rashid Ghazi—a martyr and there were calls to avenge his death.

After a surprisingly quick condemnation of the operation by Al Qaeda deputy Ayman Al Zawahiri—his message calling on Pakistanis to rise against Musharraf came a mere 24 hours after the operation—**TERROR ZONE: Police examine the site of car bomb blast in Peshawar**

